shared Akbar's appetite for expansion, and when Abdullah Khan took Badakhshan in 1584, Mirza Hakim wrote to Akbar in a panic, worried that the Uzbek ruler would swoop further east. The chastised lord of Kabul did not have to suffer his anxiety very long: the next year, in July 1585, Hakim died.

Abul Fazl hints that it was as much destiny as drink that did him in – any opponent of Akbar's was fated to a bad end, and the 'death of this young man is a fresh instance of it'. He may well be right, in that Hakim gave up the fight. He was barely in his thirties, but he had lived a battle-worn life: his mother keeping a bloodstained grip on Kabul for her child; Sulaiman and Haram making repeated bids for his throne; his own daring but ill-planned assaults on Lahore; and his hunger for a fortune as great as his brother's – all come to nothing, now, as he lived out his days at Akbar's pleasure. If all the joy that remained to Hakim was in his drink, it is no surprise.

Akbar may or may not have mourned his half-brother's death, but he did react to it. Abdullah of Turan was not a man to forgo the temptation of an unoccupied Kabul; and there were rumours that the Kabuli chiefs, too, were planning to ally with Turan, using Hakim's young children in their negotiations. Akbar sent Man Singh from Punjab to Kabul, and the emperor himself left Fatehpur within three weeks of Hakim's death, marching north to Lahore.

Man Singh arrived just in time to stop Hakim's Uncle Faridun – the 'leprous spot' who once urged the prince to invade Hindustan – from smuggling Hakim's two sons off to Turan. Instead, Man Singh bundled the boys and Faridun to Rawalpindi, where Akbar met them, took the young princes in his care, and put Faridun in prison.

Kabul was safe; but with the province still divided in its loyalties, the time was not right, clearly, to march against the powerful monarch of Turan. Having arrived in Punjab, however, Akbar would stay on. With his hapless nobility in tow, the emperor settled in Lahore.

The city had many attractions. Father Monserrate describes it as 'second to none, either in Asia or in Europe, with regard to size, population, and wealth'. Every kind of imported merchandise was available and every kind of 'art or craft useful to human life' was practised; the Father was particularly delighted with the perfumes, whose 'scent in the early morning